

2025 Media Institute

Conference Theme

Image Makers: Shaping Culture, Inspiring Change Through Media

In every society, those who craft and share stories—and inform the public through words, images, and sound—play a vital role in shaping how people see themselves, their communities, and the world. This year's theme, Image Makers: Shaping Culture, Inspiring Change Through Media, affirms the influence of broadcasters, storytellers, and content creators as agents of cultural definition and transformation. By telling stories that reflect both the challenges and the hopes of the communities they serve, media professionals contribute meaningfully to the ongoing work of nation building—promoting public understanding, shared values, and social cohesion. In serving the public good and advancing the welfare of nations, image makers do more than document events—they help shape the moral and imaginative framework of the societies they call home.

Tuesday, June 24 — Day 1

Keynote Address: The Influence of Image Makers: Media's Call to Shape Culture and Promote the Welfare of Nations

Troy Miller, President and CEO, National Religious Broadcasters.

Management & Broadcasting Track (Small Tent)

Radio 101

Sharon Geiger

An essential overview for new radio talent and a refresher for veterans. Covers voice work, format basics, and audience engagement.

East Three-Legged Stool of Media Effectiveness

Chuck Pollak

Understand the dynamic interplay between your audience, team, and partners. Learn how to align these stakeholders to create sustainable and mission-driven media efforts.

What Do I Talk About On Air? Topics and Show Prep

Sharon Geiger

Learn to prepare engaging, relevant content that keeps your audience coming back. Emphasis on storytelling, structure, and sourcing ideas.

Media Planning

Chuck Pollak

Explore the integration of audio, video, text, and digital effects in modern media planning. Discussion includes channel convergence and cohesive storytelling approaches.

Basic Interview Skills

Sharon Geiger

Master the art of asking compelling questions. This session focuses on listener-centered interviewing that reveals depth and connects emotionally.

Media Resourcing

Chuck Pollak

Practical strategies for funding media projects through commercial sales, sponsorships, and fundraising. A must for anyone managing the business side of media.

Production and Storytelling Track (Large Tent)

Design That Connects: Visual Principles for Better Communication

Vic Costello

Learn core visual design principles like alignment, contrast, and hierarchy that improve clarity and impact across all media formats.

Visual Storytelling Through Photographic Composition

Jeff Wilson

Explore composition techniques in photography to tell powerful visual stories. Emphasis on framing, depth, and subject placement.

Writing 101

Don Geiger

An introductory session for refining writing fundamentals across media formats. Ideal for emerging communicators and anyone looking to sharpen their messaging.

AI 2025: What I've Learned and How It's Changing My Work

Vic Costello

Explore the latest in generative AI and content creation tools with real-world examples of how AI is transforming research, writing, editing, and production workflows.

Pre-production: Storyboarding, Shot Lists, and How AI Changes the Game

Jeff Wilson

Learn to map out visual stories through planning tools and discover how AI accelerates preproduction processes like scripting and visualization.

The Role of AI in Writing

Don Geiger

Examine how AI tools are shaping content generation, editing, and brainstorming processes. Discussion includes both productivity benefits and creative limitations.

Wednesday, June 25 — Day 2

Management & Broadcasting Track (Small Tent)

On Air – Keeping Values and Ethics Front and Center

Sharon Geiger

This session explores how to incorporate personal convictions, ethical perspectives, or faith-informed viewpoints into on-air content in a way that feels natural, respectful, and inclusive.

Leadership and Character in a Time of Crises

Troy Miller

What kind of leadership does the media world need when crises emerge? This session explores the importance of ethical leadership, steady decision-making, and integrity in moments of organizational or cultural upheaval.

Broadcast Media Management

Chuck Pollak

A look at the multi-dimensional role of a media manager, balancing vision with operational excellence. Learn leadership strategies for managing talent, budgets, and content pipelines.

Media Strategy and Vision

Chuck Pollak

Strategic vision is essential for media organizations that want to thrive in today's fast-paced environment. Learn mission-driven leadership, adaptive strategy, and visionary thinking.

The Art of the Turn-Around: Organizational Recovery and Prosperity

Troy Miller

Media ministries and organizations often face difficult seasons. In this session, learn from shared lessons in resilience, renewal, and visionary recovery for teams navigating stagnation, decline, or disruption.

Building Community: Listener Engagement

Sharon Geiger

Discover ways to extend your on-air presence into real community impact. Strategies for feedback, local involvement, and ministry engagement.

Accounting: Accountability in the Media Marketplace

Troy Miller

This session tackles the spiritual and strategic significance of accountability. From financial transparency to mission alignment, learn how principled stewardship builds trust, longevity, and effectiveness in media leadership.

Q&A with Troy Miller

Troy Miller

An open forum to ask follow-up questions on leadership, ethics, media influence, and the future of faith-informed media work.

Production and Storytelling Track (Large Tent)

Planning to Succeed: Preproduction Skills for Audio and Video

Vic Costello

Discover key preproduction strategies including previsualization, script writing, story pitching, location scouting, and scheduling to improve quality and reduce production stress.

Filming Interviews for Production

Jeff Wilson

Tips for planning, shooting, and lighting interviews that look and sound professional. Guidance on capturing authenticity while maintaining control of the setting.

Writing for Print and Online

Don Geiger

Explore writing strategies for newsletters, blog posts, online articles, and more. Learn how to write clearly and persuasively in a fast-scrolling digital world.

Visual Storytelling for Video: Shooting with Purpose

Vic Costello

Master visual sequencing techniques and Z-axis composition to create engaging, story-driven video content.

Editing with AI

Jeff Wilson

Discover how AI tools assist with logging footage, rough cuts, and post-production workflows to speed up the editing process.

Writing for Social Media

Don Geiger

Discover best practices for concise, platform-tailored messaging. Learn techniques for engaging diverse audiences with strategic tone and structure.

Brand Photography

Jeff Wilson

Learn how to produce professional-quality photo content that aligns with your organization's visual identity and goals.

Storytelling as Brand Marketing

Don Geiger

Explore how compelling narratives can elevate your brand. Learn to connect mission, messaging, and audience through story.